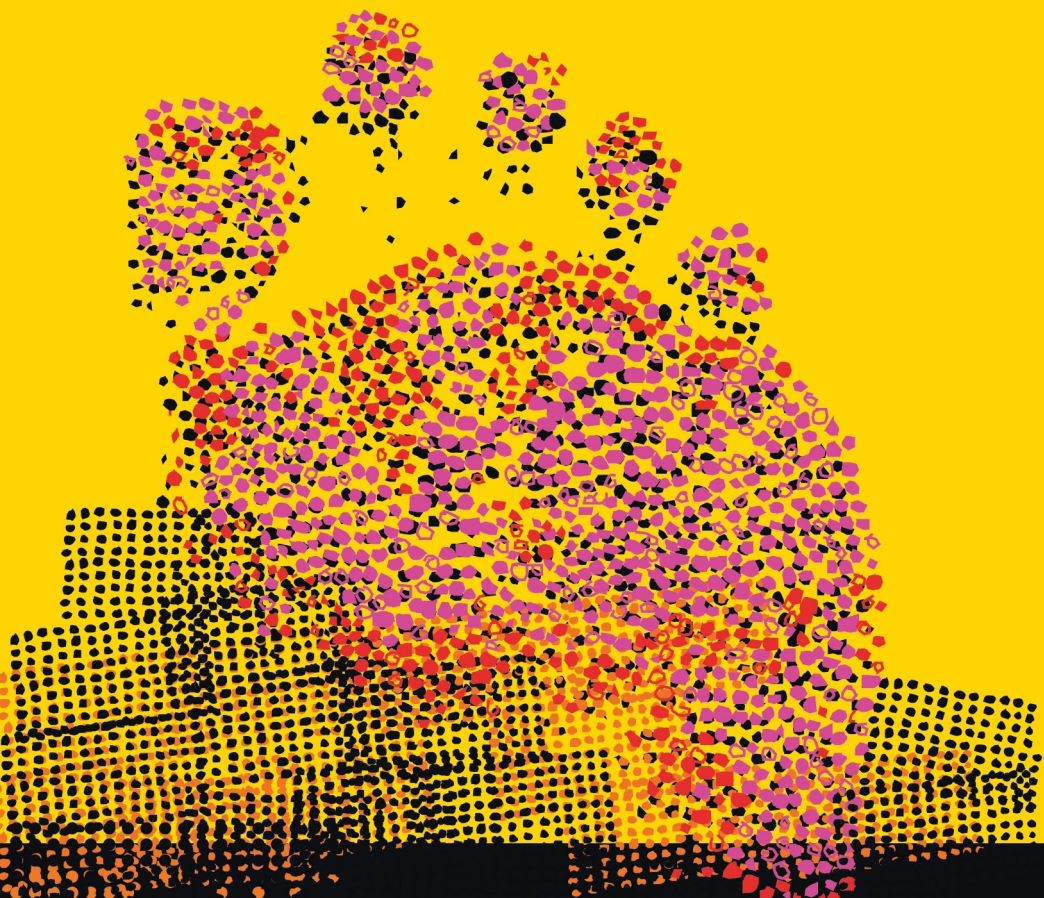


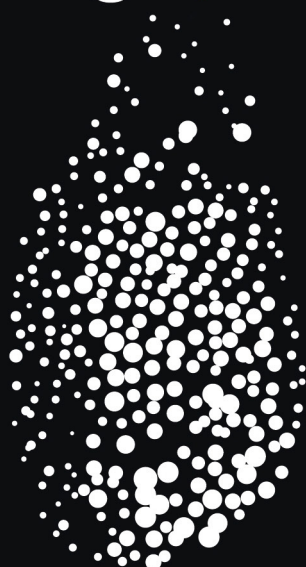


Decolonizing Methodologies

RESEARCH
AND
INDIGENOUS
PEOPLES

THIRD EDITION

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Smith



through the drafting and consultations was not only highly educative but extremely political, with member states positioning themselves in ways which advanced their own image at one level while protecting their own sovereignty at another. When the Declaration was signed in 2009, New Zealand, Australia, Canada and the United States refused to sign although subsequently, Australia, Canada and New Zealand have signed and the United States seems resolutely opposed.

An Agenda for Indigenous Research

The social movement of Indigenous peoples unleashed a whole array of activities and bursts of energy. Looking backwards it is possible now to identify themes and sub-projects which have come to engage different groups of Indigenous peoples. It is also possible to discuss the ways in which many of the themes which emerged in the late 1960s have been developed or shaped in the intervening years. These themes constitute an agenda for action. The agenda connects local, regional and global efforts which are moving towards the ideal of a self-determining Indigenous world. It is not clear yet how this world might sit alongside the current situation of nation states. It is not assumed even that nation states will necessarily remain as effective political ways of organizing polities. The rise in influence of different sorts of power blocs which cut across the nation state, such as multinational corporations, regional economic alliances and globally based interest groups, suggests a possible space for Indigenous peoples.

The research agenda is conceptualized here as constituting a programme and set of approaches that are situated within the decolonization politics of the Indigenous peoples' movement. The agenda is focused strategically on the goal of self-determination of Indigenous peoples. Self-determination in a research agenda becomes something more than a political goal. It becomes a goal of social justice which is expressed through and across a wide range of psychological, social, cultural and economic terrains. It necessarily involves the processes of transformation, of decolonization, of healing and of mobilization as peoples. The processes, approaches and methodologies – while dynamic and open to different influences and possibilities – are critical elements of a strategic research agenda.

Figure 6.1 is a simple representation of an Indigenous research agenda. The chart uses the metaphor of ocean tides. From a Pacific peoples' perspective the sea is a giver of life: it sets time and conveys

movement. Within the greater ebb and flow of the ocean are smaller localized environments which have enabled Pacific peoples to develop enduring relationships to the sea. For Polynesian peoples the significant deity of the sea is Tangaroa. Although there are many directions that can be named, the chart takes the Māori equivalent of the four directions: the northern, the eastern, the southern and the western. The tides represent movement, change, process, life, inward and outward flows of ideas, reflections and actions. The four directions named here – decolonization, healing, transformation and mobilization – represent processes. They are not goals or ends in themselves. They are processes which connect, inform and clarify the tensions between the local, the regional and the global. They are processes which can be incorporated into practices and methodologies.

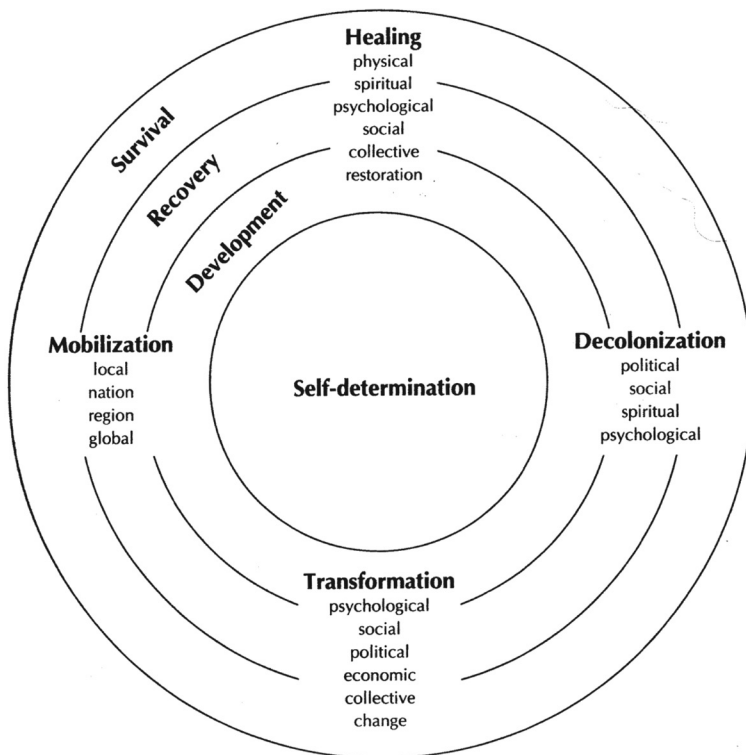


Figure 6.1 The Indigenous Research Agenda.

Four major tides are represented in the chart as survival, recovery, development, and self-determination. They are the conditions and states of being through which Indigenous communities are moving. It is not sequential development – the survival of peoples as physical beings, of languages, of social and spiritual practices, of social relations, and of the arts are all subject to some basic prioritizing. Similarly, the recovery of territories, of Indigenous rights, and histories are also subject to prioritizing and to recognition that Indigenous cultures have changed inexorably. Recovery is a selective process, often responding to immediate crises rather than a planned approach. This is related to the reality that Indigenous peoples are not in control and are subject to a continuing set of external conditions. In reality this means that specific lands and designated areas become a priority because the bulldozers are due to start destruction any day now.

The Indigenous research agenda is broad in its scope and ambitious in its intent. There are some things which make this agenda very different from the research agenda of large scientific organizations or of various national science research programmes. There are other elements, however, which are similar to any research programme which connects research to the ‘good’ of society. The elements that are different can be found in key words such as healing, decolonization, spiritual, recovery. These terms seem at odds with the research terminology of Western science, much too politically interested rather than neutral and objective. The intentions conveyed by these terms, however, are embedded in various social science research methodologies. The belief, for example, that research will ‘benefit mankind’ conveys a strong sense of social responsibility. The problem with that particular term, as outlined in previous chapters, is that Indigenous peoples are deeply cynical about the capacity, motives or methodologies of Western research to deliver any benefits to Indigenous peoples whom science has long regarded, indeed has classified, as being ‘not human’. Because of such deep cynicism there are expectations by Indigenous communities that researchers will actually ‘spell out’ in detail the likely benefits of any research.

Ethical Research Protocols

The huge credibility problem the research community faces with Indigenous peoples has also been addressed within an Indigenous agenda. Initially the problem was framed entirely in the negative, with

Indigenous individuals, communities and organizations reacting to research as something done only by white researchers to Indigenous peoples. These reactions positioned Indigenous communities as powerless and research as disempowering. There seemed little space for changing that perception. The nexus of debates rising out of the Indigenous movement, discussions raised by other interested groups in relation to ethical research, and shifts in some social science paradigms (to be discussed in Chapter 9) have created space for negotiating better research relationships. Some scholarly communities of scientists may have well-established ethical guidelines, many have not. Even if such communities have guidelines, the problem to be reiterated again is that it has been taken for granted that Indigenous peoples are the 'natural objects' of research. It is difficult to convey to the non-Indigenous world how deeply this perception of research is held by Indigenous peoples.

Many of the ethical issues have been raised by interested groups in relation to the rapid advances of science and technology and the rapid disappearance of diversity. In the debate about ethics distinctions are drawn between legal requirements and ethical codes of conduct. Indigenous groups argue that legal definitions of ethics are framed in ways which contain the Western sense of the individual and of individualized property – for example, the right of an individual to give his or her own knowledge, or the right to give informed consent. The social 'good' against which ethical standards are determined is based on the same beliefs about the individual and individualized property. Community and Indigenous rights or views in this area are generally not recognized and not respected. Indigenous peoples have attempted through the development of instruments such as treaties, charters and declarations to send clear signals to the world's scientific and research communities that open-cast mining approaches to research (see, take and destroy) are absolutely unacceptable. Debates within the Indigenous world about intellectual and cultural property rights are taking place against the background of rampant prospecting in the biodiversity and pharmaceutical fields. Cultural ethics or Indigenous codes of conduct are being promulgated by different organizations often as a sheer act of survival.

The charter of the Indigenous Tribal Peoples of the Tropical Forests signed in Penang (1993) includes statements referring to the collective rights of peoples to intellectual and cultural property, participation by Indigenous peoples in the management of projects, promotion of health systems, control over own knowledges, and an insistence that 'all investigations in our territories should be carried

out with our consent and under joint control and guidance (Article 45)'. The Mataatua Declaration on Cultural and Intellectual Property Rights of Indigenous Peoples signed in Whakatane, New Zealand (1993), addresses these issues by declaring that 'indigenous peoples of the world have the right to self-determination and in exercising that right must be recognized as the exclusive owners of their cultural and intellectual property. It insists that the first beneficiaries of indigenous knowledge must be direct indigenous descendants of that knowledge.' The Declaration calls on governments and states 'to develop policies and practices which recognize indigenous peoples as the guardians of their customary knowledge and have the right to protect and control dissemination of that know-ledge and that indigenous peoples have the right to create new knowledge based on cultural traditions.' The Declaration is one of several Indigenous peoples' declarations. Other international Indigenous statements and declarations which aim to protect Indigenous rights and enforce ethical standards include: the Amazon Basin Declaration, the Kari Oca Declaration 1993, the Pan American Health Organization, the Native Pan-American Draft Declaration, the Blue Mountain Declaration, the International Alliance of the Indigenous Tribal Peoples of the Tropical Forests Charter 1993, and the Coolangatta Statement on Indigenous Rights in Education 1993. There are many other such statements being prepared at local community level.

In the New Zealand context research ethics for Māori communities extend far beyond issues of individual consent and confidentiality. In a discussion of what may constitute sound ethical principles for research in Māori communities, Ngahuia Te Awekotuku has identified a set of responsibilities which researchers have to Māori people.²¹ Her framework is based on the code of conduct for the New Zealand Association of Social Anthropologists, which in turn is based on the American Anthropological Association's guidelines.²² Te Awekotuku sets out fairly basic guidelines aimed at respect for and protection of the 'rights, interests and sensitivities' of the people being studied. There are, however, some culturally specific ideas which are part of what is referred to as Kaupapa Māori practices.²³ These are not prescribed in codes of conduct for researchers, but tend to be prescribed for Māori researchers in cultural terms:

- 1 Aroha ki te tangata (a respect for people).
- 2 Kanohi kitea (the seen face, that is present yourself to people face to face).

- 3 Titiro, whakarongo ... korero (look, listen ... speak).
- 4 Manaaki ki te tangata (share and host people, be generous).
- 5 Kia tupato (be cautious).
- 6 Kaua e takahia te mana o te tangata (do not trample over the *mana* of people).
- 7 kia mahaki (don't flaunt your knowledge).²⁴

These sayings reflect just some of the values that are placed on the way we behave. They are very different from the 'public' image of Māori society as a forum for ritual, oratory and chiefly leaders, but they are the kinds of comments which are used to determine if someone has 'good' qualities as a person. There are several other proverbs and sayings which contain the ideals and aspirations which are worth seeking, as well as the moral messages for those who decide not to conform to the rules of practice.

More recently, Indigenous communities in Australia, Canada and New Zealand have developed useful ethical guidelines for researchers especially in relation to health research. These and other guidelines can now be found on the Internet and on agency websites. These ethical guidelines emphasize critical values that are as much about personal integrity as they are about collective responsibility, and as much about research as they are about education and other forms of engagement. In Indigenous frameworks, relationships matter. Respectful, reciprocal, genuine relationships lie at the heart of community life and community development.

From Indigenous perspectives ethical codes of conduct serve partly the same purpose as the protocols which govern our relationships with each other and with the environment. The term 'respect' is consistently used by Indigenous peoples to underscore the significance of our relationships and humanity. Through respect the place of everyone and everything in the universe is kept in balance and harmony. Respect is a reciprocal, shared, constantly interchanging principle which is expressed through all aspects of social conduct. Haig-Brown and Archibald write that 'to be in harmony with oneself, other members of the animal kingdom, and other elements of nature requires that First Nations people respect the gift of each entity and establish and maintain respectful, reciprocal relations with each.'²⁵ The denial by the West of humanity to Indigenous peoples, the denial of citizenship and human rights, the denial of the right to self-determination – all these demonstrate palpably the enormous lack of respect which has marked the relations of Indigenous and non-Indigenous peoples.

Chapter 8

TWENTY-FIVE INDIGENOUS PROJECTS

The implications for Indigenous research which have been derived from the imperatives inside the struggles of the 1970s seem to be clear and straightforward: the survival of peoples, cultures and languages; the struggle to become self-determining, the need to take back control of our destinies. These imperatives have demanded more than rhetoric and acts of defiance. The acts of reclaiming, reformulating and reconstituting Indigenous cultures and languages have required the mounting of an ambitious research programme, one that is very strategic in its purpose and activities and relentless in its pursuit of social justice. Within the programme are a number of very distinct projects. Themes such as cultural survival, self-determination, healing, restoration and social justice are engaging Indigenous researchers and communities in a diverse array of projects. The projects intersect with each other in various ways. They have multiple goals and involve different Indigenous communities of interest. Some projects, for example, have been driven by lawyers and constitutional experts, others by women and health workers, or by social workers and policy analysts. This chapter sets out 25 different projects currently being pursued by Indigenous communities. The projects constitute a very complex research programme. Each one intersects with the agenda for Indigenous research discussed in Chapter 6 in two or three different ways, that is by site/s and by processes. Each project is outlined to give a bare indication of the parameters offered within it and how these may link in with some of the others.

It is not claimed that the projects are entirely Indigenous, or that they have been created by Indigenous researchers. Some approaches have arisen out of social science methodologies, which in turn have arisen out of methodological issues raised by research with various oppressed groups. Some projects invite multi-disciplinary research approaches. Others have arisen more directly out of Indigenous practices. There are two technical points to make here. First, while most projects fall well within what will be recognized as empirical research, not all do.

Some important work is related to theorizing Indigenous issues at the level of ideas, policy analysis and critical debate, and to setting out in writing Indigenous spiritual beliefs and world views. Second, the focus is primarily on social science research projects rather than what may be happening in the natural or physical sciences or technology. There is one technical distinction to clarify. In the chapter I draw on Sandra Harding's very simple distinction between methodology and method, that is, 'A research methodology is a theory and analysis of how research does or should proceed', while 'A research method is a technique for (or way of proceeding in) gathering evidence.'¹ Methodology is important because it frames the questions being asked, determines the set of instruments and methods to be employed, and shapes the analyses. Within an Indigenous framework, methodological debates are ones concerned with the broader politics and strategic goals of Indigenous research. It is at this level that researchers have to clarify and justify their intentions. Methods become the means and procedures through which the central problems of the research are addressed. Indigenous methodologies are often a mix of existing methodological approaches and Indigenous practices. The mix reflects the training of Indigenous researchers, which continues to be within the academy, and the parameters and common sense understandings of research which govern how Indigenous communities and researchers define their activities.

The Projects

The following projects are not ranked or listed in any particular order.

1 Claiming

In a sense colonialism has reduced Indigenous peoples to making claims and assertions about our rights and dues. It is an approach that has a certain noisiness to it. Indigenous peoples, however, have transformed claiming into an interesting and dynamic process. Considerable work and energy have gone into developing the methodologies which relate to 'claiming' and 'reclaiming'. The formal claims process demanded by tribunals, courts and governments has required some Indigenous groups to conduct intensive research projects, resulting in the writing of nation, tribe and family histories. These 'histories' have a focus and purpose; that is, to establish the legitimacy of the claims being asserted

for the rest of time. Because they have been written to support claims to territories and resources, or about past injustices, they have been constructed around selected stories. These claiming histories have also been written for different audiences. One audience is the formal court or tribunal audience, which is mainly non-Indigenous; another is the general non-Indigenous population; and a third is the people themselves. For this last audience the histories are also important teaching histories. They teach both the non-Indigenous audience and the new generations of Indigenous peoples an official account of their collective story. But, importantly, it is a history which has no ending because it assumes that once justice has been done the people will continue their journey. It may be that in time the histories have to be rewritten around other priorities.

2 *Testimonies* (testimonio)

'My Name is Rigoberta Menchu, I am twenty-three years old, and this is my testimony.'²

Testimonies intersect with claiming because they are a means through which oral evidence is presented to a particular type of audience. There is a formality to testimonies and a notion that truth is being revealed 'under oath'. Indigenous testimonies are a way of talking about an extremely painful event or series of events.³ The formality of testimony provides a structure within which events can be related and feelings expressed.⁴ A testimony is also a form through which the voice of a 'witness' is accorded space and protection. It can be constructed as a monologue and as a public performance. The structure of testimony – its formality, context and sense of immediacy – appeals to many Indigenous participants, particularly elders. It is an approach that translates well to a formal written document. While the listener may ask questions, testimonies structure the responses, silencing certain types of questions and formalizing others. *Testimonio* is more familiar to Latin American contexts as a narrative of collective memory: it has become one of a number of literary methods for making sense of histories, of voices and representation, and of the political narrative of oppression.⁵

3 *Story telling*

Story telling, oral histories, the perspectives of elders and of women have become an integral part of all Indigenous research. Each individual

story is powerful. But the point about the stories is not that they simply tell a story, or tell a story simply. These new stories contribute to a collective story in which every Indigenous person has a place. For many Indigenous writers stories are ways of passing down the beliefs and values of a culture in the hope that the new generations will treasure them and pass the story down further. The story and the story teller both serve to connect the past with the future, one generation with the other, the land with the people and the people with the story. As a research tool, Russell Bishop suggests, story telling is a useful and culturally appropriate way of representing the 'diversities of truth' within which the story teller rather than the researcher retains control.⁶ Margaret Kovach argues that stories are connected to knowing, that the story is both method and meaning, and is a central feature of Indigenous research and knowledge methodologies.⁷

Jo-ann Archibald describes story as work that educates the heart, the mind, the body and the spirit. She suggests that stories engage listeners and the story teller in a respectful relationship of reciprocity that creates and sustains oral cultures.⁸ Intrinsic in story telling is a focus on dialogue and conversations amongst ourselves as Indigenous peoples, to ourselves and for ourselves. Such approaches fit well with the oral traditions which are still a reality in day-to-day Indigenous lives. Importantly, story telling is also about humour and gossip and creativity. Stories tell of love and sexual encounters, of war and revenge. Their themes tell us about our cultures. Stories employ familiar characters and motifs which can reassure as well as challenge. Familiar characters can be invested with the qualities of an individual or can be used to invoke a set of shared understandings and histories.

4 Celebrating survival – survivance

Celebrating survival is a particular sort of approach. Non-Indigenous research has been intent on documenting the demise and cultural assimilation of Indigenous peoples. Instead it is possible to celebrate survival, or what Gerald Vizenor has called 'survivance' – survival and resistance.⁹ Survivance accentuates the degree to which Indigenous peoples and communities have retained cultural and spiritual values and authenticity in resisting colonialism. The approach is reflected sometimes in story form, sometimes in popular music and sometimes as an event in which artists and story tellers come together to celebrate collectively a sense of life and diversity and connectedness. Events and accounts which focus on the active resistance are important not just

because they speak to our survival, but because they celebrate our being at an ordinary human level and affirm our identities as Indigenous women and men. Gregory Cajete writes that 'celebrating is a natural outcome of spiritual sharing and it too can take a diversity of forms. It is an individual and communal process that celebrates the mystery of life and the journey that each of us takes. Celebration is a way of spreading the lights around.'¹⁰

5 Remembering

The remembering of a people relates not so much to an idealized remembering of a golden past but more specifically to the remembering of a painful past, remembering in terms of connecting bodies with place and experience, and, importantly, people's responses to that pain. While collectively Indigenous communities can talk through the history of traumatic events, there are frequent silences and intervals in the stories about what happened after the event. Often there is no collective remembering as communities were systematically ripped apart, children were removed for adoption, and extended families separated across different reserves and national boundaries. In these experiences the obliteration of memory was a deliberate strategy of oppression. The aftermath of such pain was borne by individuals or smaller family units, sometimes unconsciously, or consciously obliterated through alcohol, violence and self-destruction. Communities often turned inward and let their suffering give way to a desire to be dead. Violence and family abuse became entrenched in communities which had no hope. White society did not see and did not care. This form of remembering is painful because it involves remembering not just what colonization was about but what being de-humanized meant for our own cultural practices. Both healing and transformation, after what is referred to as historical trauma, become crucial strategies in any approach that asks a community to remember what they may have decided unconsciously or consciously to forget.

6 Indigenizing and indigenist processes

This project has two dimensions. The first one is similar to that which has occurred in literature, with a centring in consciousness of the landscapes, images, languages, themes, metaphors and stories of the Indigenous world, and the disconnecting of many of the cultural ties between the settler society and its metropolitan homeland. This project involves non-Indigenous

activists and intellectuals. The second aspect is more of an Indigenous project. The term is used more frequently in South and Central America. The term centres a politics of Indigenous identity and Indigenous cultural action. M. Annette Jaimes refers to indigenism as being grounded in the alternative conceptions of world view and value systems: 'These differences provide a basis for a conceptualization of Indigenism that counters the negative connotations of its meanings in Third World countries, where it has become synonymous with the "primitive", or with backwardness among superstitious peoples.'¹¹ Lester Rigney, an Aborigine researcher working from Flinders University in South Australia, names the approach he takes as indigenist research: it borrows freely from feminist and other critical approaches to research, but privileges Indigenous voices. In the United States, Karina Walters and Jane Simoni have developed an 'indigenist' stress-coping model for addressing the 'soul wound' of historical trauma and contemporary discrimination against Native women.¹²

7 Intervening

Intervening takes action research to mean literally the process of being proactive and of becoming involved as an interested worker for change. Intervention-based projects are usually designed around making structural and cultural changes. Graham Smith describes this approach as a necessary approach when faced with crisis conditions. Smith argues

firstly, that Māori educational crises continue – this points to a failure of educational policy reforms, research and researchers. Secondly, educational researchers have continued to fail to intervene because of the lack of responsibility and accountability placed on researchers and policy makers. Thirdly much of research has been counter productive to Māori interests, and has merely served the dominant Pakeha group interests, by maintaining the status quo of unequal power distribution.¹³

Intervention is often used against Indigenous communities – for example, as an excuse to invade and occupy territories under the pretence of saving or rescuing an Indigenous community. In 2008 the Australian government intervened in the Northern Territory, ostensibly as an emergency reaction to widespread child abuse. The use of the armed forces on its own citizens in a democratic country is rare, but was justified under the rules of an emergency and was supported by some Aborigine activists. The Indigenous intervening project carries with

it some working principles. For example, the community itself invites the project in and sets out its parameters. The various departments and agencies involved in such a project are also expected to be willing to change themselves in some way – to redirect policy, design new programmes or train staff differently. Intervening is thus directed at changing institutions that deal with Indigenous peoples, and not at changing Indigenous peoples to fit the structures.

8 Revitalizing and regenerating

Indigenous languages, their arts and their cultural practices are in various states of crisis. Many Indigenous languages are officially ‘dead’, with fewer than a hundred speakers. Others are in the last stages before what is described by linguists as ‘language death’. Revitalization initiatives in languages encompass education, broadcasting, publishing and community-based programmes. Margie Hohepa has used the term regeneration rather than revitalization to argue that a language does not die and does not need to be brought to life; rather, the generations of people who speak the language die, and the new generations need to make the language live by speaking it. Indigenous languages are also described as endangered, with various estimates that 3,000 language will be extinct by the end of the twenty-first century.¹⁴ While the Welsh people are not formally part of the Indigenous peoples’ movements as described in Chapter 6, their programmes are often studied as examples of Indigenous achievement. In the cases of Māori and Welsh languages, there is a clear singular language. Many places have to battle for the survival of several languages spoken by small populations. In Canada, for example, most of the Indigenous languages could be categorized as being on the verge of extinction. British Columbia has a diverse range of Indigenous languages, all of which require support. Literacy campaigns tend to frame language survival programmes as being of lesser significance than national literacy. Such campaigns are designed around either official languages or one or two dominant languages. The Indigenous language is often regarded as being subversive to national interests and national literacy campaigns, and is actively killed off – a process that Tove Skutnabb-Kangas and Dunbar have called linguistic genocide.¹⁵

9 Connecting

The importance of making connections and affirming connectedness has been noted by other minority group researchers. Connectedness

positions individuals in sets of relationships with other people and with the environment. Many Indigenous creation stories link people through genealogy to the land, to stars and other places in the universe, to birds and fish, animals, insects and plants. To be connected is to be whole. The project of connecting is pursued in New South Wales in one form as literally connecting members of families with each other. A link programme has been designed to restore the descendants of 'stolen children', ones forcibly taken from their families and adopted, to their family connections. Forced adoption and dehumanizing child welfare practices were carried out in many Indigenous contexts. Being reconnected to their families and their culture has been a painful journey for many of these children, now adults. Connecting also involves connecting people to their traditional lands through the restoration of specific rituals and practices. In New Zealand one example of this is the practice of burying the afterbirth in the land. The word for afterbirth is the same as the word for land, *whenua*. The practice was prohibited as Māori mothers were forced to have their babies in hospitals rather than at home. Now the policies and hospital practices have changed and Māori parents have reinstituted the practice of taking the afterbirth and burying it in traditional territory. Connecting children to their land and their genealogies through this process is also part of a larger health project designed to encourage young Māori mothers to take better care of themselves and their babies through stronger cultural supports. Connecting is related to issues of identity and place, to spiritual relationships and community well-being.

There are other challenges in relation to the project of connecting. Researchers, policy makers, educators, and social service providers who work with or whose work impacts on Indigenous communities need to have a critical conscience about ensuring that their activities connect in humanizing ways with Indigenous communities. It is a very common experience to hear Indigenous communities outline the multiple ways in which agencies and individuals treat them with disrespect and disregard. Connecting is about establishing good relations.

10 Reading

Critical rereading of Western history and the Indigenous presence in the making of that history, once a school curriculum designed to assimilate Indigenous children, has taken on a different impetus. The new reading programme is motivated partly by a research drive to establish and support claims, but also by a need to understand what

has informed both internal colonialism and new forms of colonization. The genealogy of colonialism is being mapped and used as a way to locate a different sort of origin story: the origins of imperial policies and practices, the origins of the imperial visions, the origins of ideas and values. These origin stories are deconstructed accounts of the West, its history through the eyes of Indigenous and colonized peoples. The rereading of imperial history by post-colonial and cultural studies scholars provides a different, much more critical approach to history than was previously acceptable. It is no longer the single narrative story of important white imperial figures, adventurers and heroes who fought their way through undiscovered lands to establish imperial rule and bring civilization and salvation to 'barbaric savages' who lived in 'utter degradation'.

11 Writing and theory making

Indigenous people are writing and theory making. In Chapter 1 the writing project was named as 'the empire writes back' project. In a localized context, however, writing is employed in a variety of imaginative, critical, and also quite functional ways. Māori author Witi Ihimaera has assembled a five-volume anthology of Māori literature representing, he argues, the 'crossroads ... of a literature of a past and a literature of a present and future'.¹⁶ The title of an anthology of Native Women's writings of North America, *Reinventing the Enemy's Language*, gives a sense of the issues being explored through writing.¹⁷ Similar anthologies and works of Indigenous literature are being published around the world by Indigenous writers for Indigenous reading audiences. The boundaries of poetry, plays, song writing, fiction and non-fiction are blurred as Indigenous writers seek to use language in ways that capture the messages, nuances and flavour of Indigenous lives. Native literary and film theorists have also emerged – among them Craig Womack, Robert Warrior and Leonie Pihama – who follow in the critical anti-colonial tradition of Ngũgĩ Wa'Thiong'o and argue for the significance of Indigenous views in Indigenous literature and film.¹⁸ The activity of writing has produced the related activity of publishing. Indigenous publishing companies, language resources and focused academic journals such as *AlterNative: An International Journal of Indigenous Peoples* or the *Canadian Journal of Native Education*, or *Pimatisiwin: A Journal of Aboriginal and Indigenous Community Health* are all example of serious engagement with writing. Language revitalization initiatives have created a demand for multi-media language resources for children.

In the Western Isles of Scotland, a Stornaway publishing house called Acair has produced children's comic books in Scottish Gaelic, and cookbooks and other material which support the Gaelic language. Similar small publishing groups are operating across the Indigenous world. Writing workshops and writing courses offered by Indigenous writers like Okanagan scholar Jeannette Armstrong for Indigenous people who want to write are held in many places.¹⁹ The work of authors such as Patricia Grace, Paula Gunn Allen, Louise Erdrich, Witi Ihimaera and Sally Morgan is read by both Indigenous and non-Indigenous audiences. Biographies and autobiographies including those 'which are accounts told to a non-Indigenous person', are sought after by a new reading audience of Indigenous people.

12 Representing

Indigenous communities have struggled since colonization to be able to exercise what is viewed as a fundamental right, that is to represent ourselves. The representing project spans both the notion of representation as a political concept and representation as a form of voice and expression. In the political sense colonialism specifically excluded Indigenous peoples from any form of decision making. States and governments have long made decisions hostile to the interests of Indigenous communities, justifying these by offering the paternalistic view that Indigenous peoples were like children who needed others to protect them and decide what was in their best interests. Paternalism is still present in many forms in the way governments, local bodies and non-government agencies decide on issues which have an impact on Indigenous communities. Being able as a minimum right to voice the views and opinions of Indigenous communities in various decision-making bodies is still a focus of struggle. Even at the minimal level of representation Indigenous communities are often 'thrown in' with all other minorities, as one voice amongst many. The politics of sovereignty and self-determination have been about resisting being thrown in with every other minority group by making claims on the basis of prior rights.

Representation is also a project of Indigenous artists, writers, poets, film makers and others who attempt to express an Indigenous spirit, experience or world view. Representation of Indigenous peoples by Indigenous people is about countering the dominant society's image of Indigenous peoples, their lifestyles and belief systems. It is also about proposing solutions to the real-life dilemmas that Indigenous

communities confront, and trying to capture the complexities of being Indigenous. Many of the dilemmas are internalized stress factors in community life, which are neither named nor voiced because they are either taken for granted or hidden by a community. And there is the humour of Alexie Sherman, who wrote *Reservation Blues*. Film makers like Merata Mita have a very clear purpose in their work which locates it firmly within a decolonization framework.

Not surprisingly, when my obsessive struggle with filmmaking began, it was with the issues that most concerned us as Māori women that I became preoccupied – the issues of injustice, land, te reo Māori [Māori language], the Treaty, and racism. Add to that women and gender issues, and for those who don't know, these are the things that consume us, consume our energy, beset us every moment of our daily lives; they are brutalising, violent, and some of us die because of them.²⁰

13 *Gendering*

Gendering Indigenous debates, whether they are related to the politics of self-determination or the politics of the family, is concerned with issues arising from the relations between Indigenous men and women that have come about through colonialism. Colonization is recognized as having had a destructive effect on Indigenous gender relations that reached out across all spheres of Indigenous society. Family organization, child rearing, political and spiritual life, work and social activities were all disordered by a colonial system that positioned its own women as the property of men, with primarily domestic roles. Women across many different Indigenous societies claim an entirely different relationship, one embedded in beliefs about the land and the universe, about the spiritual significance of women, and about the collective endeavours that were required in the organization of society. Indigenous women would argue that their traditional roles included full participation in many aspects of political decision making and marked gender separations which were complementary in order to maintain harmony and stability. Gendering contemporary Indigenous debates – for example, debates about economic development, about domestic violence, HIV/AIDs and war – occurs inside Indigenous communities and – while colonialism is an important topic in other contexts, such as in Western feminist debates – analysis of colonialism is a central tenet of Indigenous feminism. A key challenge within contemporary Indigenous

politics is the restoration to women of what are seen as their traditional roles, rights and responsibilities. Aroha Mead gives an account of a statement delivered by two Māori women to the Twelfth Session (1994) of the United Nations Working Group on Indigenous Peoples, which addressed the way colonialism has influenced Indigenous men and had a detrimental affect on Indigenous gender relations.

[N]ever before have I witnessed what occurred while the full statement was being read out. Indigenous women sitting within their delegations were visibly moved – some looked around to see who was talking about their pain – some gave victory signals and physical signs of agreement, and many, perhaps even the majority, sat stoically, with tears swelling in their eyes. The words broke through the barriers of language and regionalism. A raw wound was clearly touched.²¹

14 Envisioning

One of the strategies that Indigenous peoples have employed effectively to bind people together politically asks that people imagine a future, that they rise above present-day situations which are generally depressing, dream a new dream and set a new vision. The confidence of knowing that we have survived and can only go forward provides some impetus to a process of envisioning. The power of Indigenous peoples to change their own lives and set new directions, despite their impoverished and oppressed conditions, speaks to the politics of survivance. Gregory Cajete talks about vision making as knowledge making, is one the methodologies for producing Indigenous knowledge through vision quests and dreaming, a reflection of the spirit which is also the mind.

Sometimes the visions which bind people were set a long time ago and have been passed down the generations as poems, songs, stories, proverbs or sayings. Every Indigenous community probably has special sayings, predictions, riddles and proverbs which are debated frequently and raised both informally and formally. Children are socialized into these sayings and pass them down to their own children. The profound statements of Indigenous leaders from the last century and the centuries before are often written in diaries and notebooks, carved into stone, or distributed by T-shirt and poster. Often the original source of the comment has been forgotten but the power of the words remain. They make our spirits soar and give us hope. Indigenous people have borrowed freely from each other and it is not uncommon to find the saying of an Indian chief stuck to the kitchen wall in a Māori home,

or the saying of a Māori chief embroidered into a wall hanging in an Aborigine home. These sayings have acted like resistance codes which can be passed down by word of mouth to the next person, to the next generation.

15 Reframing

Reframing is about taking much greater control over the ways in which Indigenous issues and social problems are discussed and handled. One of the reasons why so many of the social problems which beset Indigenous communities are never solved is that the issues have been framed in a particular way. For example, governments and social agencies have failed to see many Indigenous social problems as being related to any sort of history. They have framed Indigenous issues in the 'Indigenous problem' basket, to be handled in the usual cynical and paternalistic manner. The framing of an issue is about making decisions about its parameters, about what is in the foreground, what is in the background, and what shadings or complexities exist within the frame. The project of reframing is related to defining the problem or issue and determining how best to solve that problem. Many Indigenous activists have argued that such things as mental illness, alcoholism and suicide, for example, are not about psychological and individualized failure but about colonization or lack of collective self-determination. Many community health initiatives address the whole community, its history and its wider context, as part of the problem and part of the solution.

Reframing occurs in other contexts where Indigenous people resist being boxed and labelled according to categories which do not fit. This is particularly pertinent in relation to various development programmes, government and non-government. In the case of Māori, for example, a Māori language initiative for young children from birth to school age – known as *Te Kohanga Reo*, or Māori language nests – constantly has to explain why it is not a child-care centre but a language and culture initiative for young children. The problem of definition is important in this case because it affects funding, but the constant need to justify difference is experienced by many other communities whose initiatives are about changing things on a holistic basis rather than endorsing the individualized programme emphasis of government models. The need to reframe is about retaining the strengths of a vision and the participation of a whole community.

Reframing occurs also within the way Indigenous people write or engage with theories and accounts of what it means to be Indigenous.

In the politics of Indigenous women, for example, there is continuing resistance to the way Western feminists have attempted to define the issues for Indigenous women and categorize the positions in which Indigenous women should be located. Moves to discuss patriarchy without addressing imperialism and racism are always reframed by Indigenous women, and of course other minority women, as inadequate analyses. Similarly, moves to attack Indigenous culture or Indigenous men 'as a group' are also resisted because for Indigenous women the issues are far more complex and the objective of analysis is always focused on solving problems. In the end Indigenous men and women have to live together in a world in which both genders are under attack.

16 Restoring

Indigenous peoples across the world have disproportionately high rates of imprisonment, suicide and alcoholism. Some Indigenous activists regard these rates as the continuation of a war. Says Bobbi Sykes, 'The main question, which has not been addressed by government, is the legitimacy or otherwise of the assumption that white domination of Aboriginal people is in itself a concept of justice.'²² For Aborigines the high rates of black deaths in custody eventually provoked the establishment of a Royal Commission of Inquiry in 1987 into a problem which had been hidden for many years. The Aborigine rates of death in custody was said to be higher than the rate in apartheid South Africa. Inside the incarceration rates for Indigenous peoples are similar rates for youth offending and for Indigenous women. In the health arena Indigenous people have high rates of morbidity and mortality. Māori women have one of the highest rates of lung cancer in the world. Māori suicide rates, both male and female, have risen sharply over the last decade, with New Zealand rates amongst the highest in OECD countries. Aborigine rates of illness have frequently been cited as examples of 'Fourth World' rates, which are worse than the rates in developing Third World states, and are made more horrific by the fact that these communities live in nations that have the highest standards of living.

Restoring well-being – spiritually, emotionally, physically and materially – has involved social workers and health workers in a range of initiatives, some of which have been incorporated into mainstream programmes. Restorative justice in Canada, for example, applies concepts of the 'healing circle' and victim restoration which are based on Indigenous processes. These systems have been discussed widely and used to motivate other societies to develop better ways of dealing with offenders and

victims. In New Zealand adoption policies and programmes for dealing with children have similarly coopted Indigenous practices. Restoring is a project which is conceived as a holistic approach to problem solving. It is holistic in terms of the emotional, spiritual and physical nexus, and also in terms of the individual and the collective, the political and the cultural. Restorative programmes are based on a model of healing rather than of punishing. They sometimes employ concepts such as public shaming as a way of provoking individual accountability and collective problem solving. Health programmes addressing basic health issues have begun to seek ways to connect with Indigenous communities through appropriate public health policy and practice models. The failure of public health programmes to improve the health of Indigenous communities significantly has motivated a self-help approach by communities.

17 Returning

This project intersects with that of claiming. It involves the returning of lands, rivers and mountains to their Indigenous owners. It involves the repatriation of artefacts, remains and other cultural materials stolen or removed and taken overseas. Sykes lists the following examples: 'pickled heads, human gloves, scrotum tobacco pouches, dried scalps, pickled foetus, cicatured skins, complete stuffed, mummified children's bodies and women with child'.²³ In New Zealand the current Minister of Māori Affairs, who is a Māori, has set out a plan to return all tattooed Māori heads housed in museums and other collections across the world. They apparently number in the hundreds. In a previous chapter I discussed the house Mataatua, which has now been returned to Ngati Awa and was reopened in 2011 as a magnificent modern meeting house that is set to inspire the realization of development opportunities.

Returning also involves the living. One major tribe in New Zealand has negotiated the return of traditional food-gathering sites which will be marked out for their exclusive use by tribal members. Other programmes have been initiated to repatriate people either through ensuring their membership in official tribal registers or by physically reclaiming them. Adopted children, for example, are encouraged to seek their birth families and return to their original communities.

18 Democratizing and indigenist governance

Although Indigenous communities claim a model of democracy in their traditional ways of decision making, many contemporary Indigenous

organizations were formed through the direct involvement of states and governments. Legislation was used to establish and regulate Indigenous councils and committees, forms of representation and titles to lands. They are colonial constructions that have been taken for granted as authentic Indigenous formations. Needless to say, many councils were created as exclusively male domains while the health and welfare programmes were assigned to the women. Māori lawyer Annette Sykes argues, for example, in relation to a claim being made by Māori women to the Waitangi Tribunal, that

The essence of the claim is to bring to the forefront of the current Treaty jurisprudence, the need to look at notions of governance in Aotearoa and the exclusionary practices that exist, which inhibit and prevent participation by Māori women in the tribal models for self-determination, that have been erected under New Zealand legislation, and the erosion that this in itself has had on Te Mana Wahine in Te Ao Māori [the *mana* of women in the Māori World].²⁴

Democratizing in Indigenous terms is a process of extending participation outwards through reinstating Indigenous principles of collectivity and public debate without necessarily recreating a parliamentary or senatorial style of government. Governance has been a theme for development agencies wishing to transform underdeveloped societies and communities. In this work concepts of ‘tribe’ are hugely loaded terms that imply backwardness, ignorance, cruelty to women and children. It means that Indigenous nations and communities have to develop twenty-first-century governance approaches that are embedded in an Indigenous value system and geared to meet contemporary social challenges with the best minds and skillsets of the community.

19 Networking

Networking has become an efficient medium for stimulating information flows, educating people quickly about issues and creating extensive international talking circles. Building networks is about building knowledge and data bases which are based on the principles of relation-ships and connections. Relationships are initiated on a face-to-face basis and then maintained over many years, often without any direct contact. People’s names are passed on and introductions are used to bring new members into the network. The face-to-face encounter is about checking out an individual’s credentials, not just

their political credentials but their personalities and spirit. Networking by Indigenous peoples is a form of resistance. People are expected to position themselves clearly and state their purposes. Establishing trust is an important feature. In many states police surveillance of Indigenous activists and their families is common practice. In some states, such as Guatemala, the disappearance of Indigenous peoples has also been common practice. In these contexts networking is dangerous.

Networking is a way of making contacts between marginalized communities. By definition their marginalization excludes them from participation in the activities of the dominant non-Indigenous society, which controls most forms of communication. The project of networking is about process. Networking is a process which Indigenous peoples have used effectively to build relationships and disseminate knowledge and information.

20 Naming

This project takes its name from Brazilian educator Paulo Freire whose saying, 'name the word, name the world' (which was about literacy programmes), has been applied in the Indigenous context to literally rename the landscape. This means renaming the world using the original Indigenous names. Naming as a project of Māori people can be seen in the struggles over the geographical names of some of New Zealand's mountains and significant sites, which were renamed randomly after British people and places. Many of the Māori names have now been restored. Naming can also be seen in the naming of children. Indigenous names carried histories of people, places and events. As a result of Christian baptism practices, which introduced Christian names and family names, and schooling practices, where teachers shortened names or introduced either generic names or nicknames, many Indigenous communities hid their Indigenous names either by using them only in Indigenous ceremonies or by positioning them as second names. A more recent assertion in Māori naming practices has been to name children again with long ancestral names and to take on new names through life, both of which were once traditional practices. Children quite literally wear their history in their names.

Naming applies to other things as well. It is about retaining as much control over meanings as possible. By 'naming the world' people name their realities. For communities there are realities which can only be found, as self-evident concepts, in the Indigenous language; they can never be captured by another language.

21 Protecting

This project is multi-faceted. It is concerned with protecting peoples, communities, languages, customs and beliefs, art and ideas, natural resources and the things Indigenous peoples produce. The scale of protecting can be as enormous as the Pacific Ocean or the Amazon rainforest, and as small as an infant. It can be as real as land and as abstract as a belief about the spiritual essence of the land. Every Indigenous community is attempting to protect several different things simultaneously. In some areas alliances with non-Indigenous organizations have been beneficial in terms of rallying international support. In other areas a community is trying to protect itself by staying alive or staying off alcohol.

Some countries have identified sacred sites and have designated protected areas. Many of these, unfortunately, become tourist spots. Issues about the protection of Indigenous knowledge have been discussed at various Indigenous conferences, which have produced charters and conventions aimed at signalling to the world at large that Indigenous knowledges ought to be protected. History seems to suggest that many of these calls for international adherence to such charters will be at best highly selective. The need to protect a way of life, a language and the right to make our own history is a deep need linked to the survival of Indigenous peoples.

22 Creating

The project of creating is about transcending the basic survival mode through using a resource or capability that every Indigenous community has retained throughout colonization – the ability to create and be creative. The project of creating is not just about the artistic endeavours of individuals, but about the spirit of creating that Indigenous communities have exercised over thousands of years. Imagination enables people to rise above their own circumstances, to dream new visions and to hold on to old ones. It fosters inventions and discoveries, facilitates simple improvements to people's lives and uplifts our spirits. Creating is not the exclusive domain of the rich, nor of the technologically superior, but of the imaginative. Creating is about channelling collective creativity in order to produce solutions to Indigenous problems. Every Indigenous community has considered and come up with various innovative solutions to problems. That was before colonialism. Throughout the period of colonization Indigenous

peoples survived because of their imaginative spirit, their ability to adapt and to think around a problem.

Indigenous communities also have something to offer the non-Indigenous world. There are many programmes incorporating Indigenous elements, which on that account are viewed on the international scene as 'innovative' and unique. Indigenous peoples' ideas and beliefs about the origins of the world, their explanations of the environment, often embedded in complicated metaphors and mythic tales, are now being sought as the basis for thinking more laterally in current theories about the environment, the earth and the universe.

Communities are the ones who know the answers to their own problems, although their ideas tend to be dismissed when suggested to various agencies and governments. Visits to communities that have developed their own programmes demonstrate both flourishing creativity and the strength of commitment shown when the programme is owned by the community.

23 Negotiating

Negotiating is about thinking and acting strategically. It is about recognizing and working towards long-term goals. Patience is a quality possessed in abundance by Indigenous communities. Patience and negotiation are linked to a very long view of our survival. When one reads of the decisions made by various Indigenous leaders to accept the terms and conditions of colonization, what emerges from those stories is the concern shown by leaders for the long-term survival chances of the collective, of their own people. That was the basis of their courage and, despite the outrage younger generations of Indigenous people might feel about the deals that some leaders accepted, the broader picture across several Indigenous contexts is one of dignity and acceptance of a specific reality. Their negotiations were undertaken quite literally with guns held at their heads, with their people starving and with death all around them.

In today's environment negotiation is still about deal making and it is still about concepts of leadership. Negotiations are also about respect, self-respect and respect for the opposition. Indigenous rules of negotiation usually contain both rituals of respect and protocols for discussion. The protocols and procedures are integral to the actual negotiation; neglect or failure to acknowledge or take such protocols seriously can be read as a lack of commitment to both the process and the outcome. Many Indigenous societies are socialized into some

forms of negotiation because they are part of trading practices or basic communication styles. The contemporary negotiation project is related to self-determination, in that Indigenous nations are negotiating terms for settlements which often mean semi-autonomous government or statutory representation or control over key resources, such as natural resources within their own territories. Negotiation also occurs where small gains are at stake, however, such as when local communities have worked out an agreement with a local government or agency or another local community. The formality of negotiation is important in protecting the sanctity of the agreement which emerges. Indigenous peoples know and understand what it means for agreements to be dishonoured. The continued faith in the process of negotiating is about retaining a faith in the humanity of Indigenous beliefs, values and customary practices.

24 Discovering the beauty of our knowledge

This project is about discovering our own Indigenous knowledge and Western science and technology, and making our knowledge systems work for Indigenous development. There are very few Indigenous scientists who remain closely connected to their own Indigenous communities. Indigenous students across many contexts have struggled with Western science as it has been taught to them in schools. Traditionally, science has been hostile to Indigenous ways of knowing. Science teaching in schools has also been fraught with hostile attitudes towards Indigenous cultures, and the way Indigenous students learn. There are huge debates within the scientific community about the nature of science and how it ought to be taught. This debate is over the notion of constructivism, and concerns the extent to which knowledge is socially constructed or exists 'out there' as a body of knowledge that students simply learn. The development of ethno-science and the application of science to matters that interest Indigenous peoples, such as environmental and resource management or biodiversity, offer some new possibilities for Indigenous people to engage with the sciences they find most relevant. However, the project is as much about rediscovering Indigenous knowledge and its continued relevance to the way we lead our lives. Indigenous knowledge in terms of the environment is well recognized as traditional ecological knowledge. Indigenous knowledge extends beyond the environment, however; it has values and principles about human behaviour and ethics, about relationships, about wellness and

leading a good life. Knowledge has beauty and can make the world beautiful if used in a good way.²⁵

25 Sharing

The final project discussed here is about sharing knowledge between Indigenous peoples, around networks and across the world of Indigenous peoples. Sharing contains views about knowledge being a collective benefit and knowledge being a form of resistance. Like networking, sharing is a process that is responsive to the marginalized contexts in which Indigenous communities exist. Even in the context of New Zealand – a small country, relatively well-off in terms of televisions and communications – Māori people learn more about the issues that affect them at community gatherings held on *marae* than they do from the mainstream media. These gatherings may be for weddings or funerals, but they are also used as opportunities to keep the community informed about a wide range of things. The face-to-face nature of sharing is supplemented with local newspapers focusing on Indigenous issues and local radio stations specializing in Indigenous news and music. Sharing is also related to the failure of education systems to educate Indigenous people adequately or appropriately. It is important for keeping people informed about issues and events that affect them. It is a form of oral literacy, which connects with the story telling and formal occasions that feature in Indigenous life.

Sharing is a responsibility of research. The technical term for this is the dissemination of results, usually very boring to non-researchers, very technical and very cold. For Indigenous researchers, sharing is about demystifying knowledge and information and speaking in plain terms to the community. Community gatherings provide a very daunting forum in which to speak about research. Oral presentations conform to cultural protocols and expectations. Often the audience may need to be involved emotionally with laughter, deep reflection, sadness, anger, challenges and debate. It is a very skilled speaker who can share openly at this level within the rules of the community.

Summary

The projects touched on in this chapter are not offered as a definitive list of activities in which Indigenous communities are engaged. Since the

book was first published a number of articles and books have identified and applied specific Indigenous methodologies that use Indigenous concepts. Numerous collaborative projects are being undertaken with non-Indigenous researchers and organizations. Many of these research partnerships help to develop a trained workforce through the mentoring and guidance provided by the non-Indigenous researchers. There are also the more typical social science research projects and methodologies that have not been mentioned here. Some of these approaches, for example those in critical ethnography, have been written about and theorized by scholars working in those disciplines. The naming of the projects listed in this chapter was deliberate. I hope the message it gives to communities is that they have issues that matter, and processes and methodologies that can work for them.

Notes

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